

university-level cricket in the United Kingdom also played a significant role in shaping many players.

Burki made an impressive start to Test cricket, scoring over 650 runs at an average of more than 50 in his first two series. He eventually captained Pakistan on its tour of England in 1962. "I was initially reluctant to accept the role, but I had to accept it since most of the selection committee members were senior civil servants and I was a junior civil servant," he says with a smile.

Despite playing 177 First-Class matches, Burki featured in only 25 Tests. As he explains, the decision to step away from international cricket was influenced by his flourishing career in civil service.

"The government of Pakistan had a rule that any civil servant who was a member of a national team in any sport had to be given time off to play for the national team, and his time with the national team was considered as on duty. So, they always had to release me for international assignments. After two or three years, it became a little difficult for me because I couldn't be given good posts," Burki says.

"That's when I decided to focus on my job, and cricket took a backseat. I could never really become a full-time cricketer mainly because of my job, and also since there wasn't much cricket, there was just not enough money here," he says. Over the course of his long career as a civil servant, Burki went on to serve the Government of Pakistan as Secretary in the Ministry of Water and Power.

Part of history

However, a couple of decades after calling it quits, Burki returned to the game — albeit as the chief selector of the national team, which went on to win the World Cup title in 1992 under the leadership of his cousin, Imran Khan.

During that phase — from 1989 to 1993 — a group of young cricketers, including Inzamam-ul-Haq, Waqar Younis, Saeed Anwar, and Moin Khan, made their international debuts. "Around that time, India U-19 and Sri Lanka A teams were touring Pakistan, and



Heroic knock: Pakistan captain Javed Burki plays a shot off Leonard Coldwell during his century stand with Nasim-ul-Ghani (101). Their 197-run partnership saved Pakistan from an innings defeat at Lord's in 1962. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

this was an opportunity for me to pick newer players. So, I got together with some managers of Pakistani teams, people who managed the United Bank team, the Habib Bank team, old cricketers, and asked them about young cricketers," Burki says.

Thus, players like Inzamam and Younis rose through the ranks. With the 1992 World Cup approaching, Imran would regularly call Burki. "Imran used to keep telephoning me from England, asking: Have you found somebody? I would say, yes. When he came, we presented him Waqar Younis, Inzamam and Anwar, who he did not like. But I insisted that Anwar should be considered," he says.

The rest, of course, is history, as Anwar went on to become one of the icons of Pakistan cricket across formats. Burki also notes that maintaining discipline was never a challenge.

"The boys knew that anybody who did not perform or was indisciplined would be out of the team. From January 1989, right up to the selection of the team for the World Cup in February 1992, we had this continuity of order and discipline and channels of communication. Nobody could go around us, nobody could go and talk

to anybody on the board," he says. While many among the current generation may not be familiar with his name, Burki recalls an incident from 2006 when former India captain Rahul Dravid wished to meet him during India's tour of Pakistan. "The team was invited by a local banker for a meal, and Imran was also there. So, he called me to say that the Indian team wanted to meet me.

When I went there, it turned out to be Dravid, who wanted to meet me because he wanted to know about the tour of India in 1960-61 and asked me why the current Pakistan team was different," Burki says. "I explained that the cultures were now more diverse. Back in the 1960s, the Indian and Pakistani cultures were kind of similar, but now it was different..."

Though he continues to follow Pakistan cricket, and the team's struggles do disappoint him, Burki, sitting in a cosy corner of his Islamabad home, fondly reminisces about the game's golden days and the fierce on-field rivalry with the neighbouring nation.

While much of his time is spent with his pet dog and his parrot, Burki often finds himself missing his old friends and the cherished moments of the past.